breach of trust. This tension was starkly evident in the case of Greece's Syriza Party, which railed against the IMF during its election campaign only to enter negotiations with the Fund once in power (Henning 2017). Such mismatches between rhetoric and policy can erode leaders' credibility, exposing them to backlash from their base.

From the perspective of IOs, rhetorical attacks can inflict significant harm, though less so than when leaders cut off the flow of funds or information. Public trust is a cornerstone of an IO's ability to function effectively, as many organizations depend on a favorable public mood to implement programs and enforce agreements (Milner and Tingley 2012; Brutger and Clark 2022). Anti-IO rhetoric can sow skepticism among the public, undermining the legitimacy these institutions need to operate. Public backlash, fueled by populist messaging, can disrupt program implementation, delay negotiations, and hinder compliance with IO directives. If rhetorical attacks continue to gain traction, IOs may find themselves increasingly hamstrung, unable to enforce their mandates or garner the backing necessary to address global challenges effectively (Hurd 1999; Tallberg and Zürn 2019; Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023).

2.3 How IOs Fight Back

In the face of populist attacks, IOs are far from passive bystanders—they fight back. When confronted by populists within their ranks, IOs deploy a diverse arsenal of strategies, pursuing four primary options that can be employed individually or in tandem: appeasing populists, sidelining populists, appeasing populists' constituents, and sidelining populists' constituents. While these strategies were introduced briefly in the book's opening chapter, we now delve into each in greater detail, exploring how IOs implement these measures, the conditions that make them feasible, and the potential normative and practical trade-offs they entail.

IOs are typically reactive, addressing populist threats only after they materialize, rather than preemptively adjusting their operations. Institutional inertia, or status quo bias, often keeps reforms at bay until organizations face significant disruptions. Such path dependence has long been noted in scholarly work that highlights how entrenched rules and routines make IOs (and institutions more generally) resistant to change (Bennett and Elman